

Weekly U.S. Stock Market Report: A Record Week Amid Conflicting Signals (October 27 - October 31, 2025)

I. Executive Summary: A Week of Contradictions

This week, the U.S. stock market demonstrated a tight tug-of-war between powerful bullish catalysts and significant potential risks. The market reached new all-time highs, buoyed by three strong drivers: the Federal Reserve's confirmation of a rate cut, an easing of U.S.-China trade tensions, and robust earnings from Big Tech companies.¹ However, this optimism was immediately tempered by hawkish remarks from Fed Chair Jerome Powell, operational uncertainty caused by a data blackout from the government shutdown, and a consensus among experts that the U.S.-China truce is provisional at best.

The market's dichotomous reaction to corporate earnings—rewarding profitable growth while penalizing costly investment plans—emerged as a key theme of the week and will serve as a critical barometer for the market's future direction.

II. Market and Macroeconomic Review (October 27 - October 31, 2025)

A. Weekly Market Action: A Rally Built on Three Pillars

The week began with a powerful rally that propelled major indices to record highs. For the week, the S&P 500 gained 1.92%, the Nasdaq Composite rose 2.31%, and the Dow Jones Industrial Average advanced 2.20%.¹

- **October 27 (Monday):** The market surged on three key expectations: 1) overwhelming market anticipation of a 25bp rate cut from the Fed scheduled for later in the week³; 2)

optimism surrounding the upcoming Trump-Xi meeting at the APEC summit ³; and 3) strong earnings expected from the 'Magnificent Seven' Big Tech companies.³ This combination of positive catalysts created a strong risk-on sentiment, driving the S&P 500 up 1.2%, the Dow up 0.7%, and the Nasdaq up 1.9%.³

- **October 28 (Tuesday):** The market digested the release of the Consumer Confidence Index. The index showed little change from the previous month, which did not dampen the market's prevailing bullish sentiment.⁸ Market attention remained firmly fixed on the upcoming FOMC decision.
- **October 29 (Wednesday):** The market experienced two distinct phases. It initially reacted positively to the widely expected announcement of a 25bp rate cut.¹⁰ However, the mood shifted dramatically when Chair Powell adopted a hawkish and cautious tone during his press conference, explicitly stating that a further cut in December was "not a foregone conclusion".¹¹ This remark triggered an immediate reversal, causing the S&P 500 and Dow to close down from their intraday highs.¹⁰
- **October 30 (Thursday):** The market turned lower as it processed Powell's hawkish stance and the mixed Big Tech earnings released after Wednesday's close. Disappointing results and guidance from Meta (-11%) and Microsoft (-3%) dragged the Nasdaq down 1.6% and the S&P 500 down 1.0%.¹⁴ Positive news from the Trump-Xi meeting, including tariff reductions and a rare earths agreement, was insufficient to offset the tech-led sell-off.¹⁴
- **October 31 (Friday):** The market rebounded to close the week and month on a strong note, buoyed by Amazon's stellar earnings released after Thursday's close. A 9.6% surge in Amazon's stock lifted the Nasdaq by 0.6%, providing a positive end to the week.¹⁵ The S&P 500 rose 0.3%, and the Dow gained 0.1%.¹⁵

The market's rally is predicated on a narrative of continued monetary easing, yet the Fed is signaling a cautious pause dependent on data it cannot currently access. This reveals a significant disconnect between market expectations and the Fed's reality. The market is trading on hope, which leaves it highly vulnerable should data—once released—reinforce the Fed's cautious stance.

B. The Fed's Balancing Act

- **25bp Rate Cut:** The Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) decided to lower the target range for the federal funds rate by 25bp to 3.75%-4.00%.¹⁰ This was the second consecutive rate cut and was fully anticipated by the market.⁵ However, the decision was not unanimous, with dissents in favor of a larger 50bp cut and a hold, respectively, signaling growing divisions within the committee.¹⁷
- **Key Takeaways from Powell's Press Conference:**

- **Future Policy Path:** Powell pushed back strongly against market expectations for a December rate cut, adopting a "noticeably hawkish" tone. His statement that a further cut was "not a foregone conclusion, far from it" was the key market-moving event, triggering an immediate equity sell-off and a rise in Treasury yields.¹¹
- **Inflation and Employment:** Powell acknowledged the difficult balance the Fed faces between "upside risks to inflation" and "downside risks to employment".¹⁹ He noted that inflation has moved up since the start of the year and remains "somewhat elevated," while the labor market is showing signs of gradually cooling and weakening.¹⁹ The rate cut was justified as a response to the increased "downside risks to employment".¹⁰
- **AI Bubble Assessment:** When asked about a potential AI bubble, Powell drew a sharp distinction from the dot-com era. He argued that today's leading AI companies are generating "actual earnings" and are financing "tangible infrastructure".²¹ He viewed this massive capital expenditure not as speculation but as a long-term bet on productivity and a "visible source of growth".²⁰ While he acknowledged this creates a "policy dilemma" of productivity gains without job growth, he did not define it as a speculative bubble requiring Fed intervention.²⁰

Powell's specific mention of a "K-shaped" economy, where AI-driven growth benefits corporations and wealthier households while lower-income consumers struggle, is a crucial and nuanced observation.²⁰ It suggests the Fed is aware that headline economic data may be masking underlying weakness and deepening inequality. This K-shaped dynamic complicates the Fed's dual mandate; it means the central bank cannot simply look at aggregate data, creating an internal contradiction where policy appropriate for a booming tech sector could push the consumer-facing economy into a downturn.

C. Policymaking in the Dark: The Government Shutdown

- **Data Blackout:** The government shutdown, now in its 28th day, has halted the release of key economic data from agencies like the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) and the Census Bureau.²² This has created a "data vacuum" or "data blackout".²² Major reports, including the monthly jobs report, third-quarter GDP, and the Fed's preferred inflation gauge (PCE), were not released as scheduled this week.²³
- **Reactions to the Data Void:**
 - **The Fed:** Powell explicitly stated that the lack of data complicates policymaking and makes the outlook more uncertain.⁵ He directly linked this uncertainty to a potentially more hawkish policy stance, noting it "could be an argument in favor of caution about moving" at the December meeting.¹²
 - **Financial Institutions:** Economists from institutions like Goldman Sachs and Wells

Fargo have warned of the risk of permanent loss and distortion of October data.²² They stress that while private data is useful, it cannot replace the "gold standard" of government statistics.¹⁶

- **Market/Corporations:** The absence of data creates significant uncertainty for businesses finalizing 2026 budgets and making hiring and investment decisions, likely leading to a more cautious, risk-averse posture.²²

The data blackout is more than an inconvenience; it fundamentally impairs the ability of a data-dependent Fed to conduct monetary policy. By forcing the FOMC to navigate with an obscured view of both inflation and employment, the shutdown dramatically increases the potential for a policy mistake. The market must now price in a higher "policy error premium." The risk is no longer just about whether the Fed's models are right, but whether its inputs are even valid.

D. Geopolitics and the Market: The APEC Summit

- **U.S.-China "Truce":** The centerpiece of the APEC summit was the meeting between President Trump and President Xi, which resulted in a significant but tentative trade truce.²⁵ China agreed to suspend its export controls on rare earths and permanent magnets for one year, resume purchases of U.S. soybeans, and crack down on fentanyl precursors.²⁶ In return, the U.S. agreed to lower fentanyl-related tariffs from 20% to 10% and extend the suspension of other reciprocal tariffs for a year.²⁶
- **U.S. Alliances (South Korea & Japan):** The U.S. also signed bilateral "Technology Prosperity Deals (TPDs)" with South Korea and Japan, deepening cooperation in AI, quantum computing, and 6G and securing technology supply chains, thereby building a coalition to counter China's tech ambitions.²⁸
- **Expert Analysis and the "Trump Variable":** Expert analysis from institutions like CSIS is overwhelmingly skeptical about the durability of the agreement, characterizing it as a "pause" or "truce," not a resolution.²⁶ China's use of rare earths as leverage is seen as a "recurrent feature of its modern economic statecraft," and the broader export control framework remains in place.²⁶ Trump-related market risk appears contained as long as the tariff issue is managed, but this is a critical precondition.

The APEC outcome demonstrates a "barbell strategy" by the U.S.: pursuing short-term de-escalation with its primary strategic competitor, China, while simultaneously cementing long-term strategic technology alliances with key regional partners, Japan and South Korea. While the market cheered the truce with China, the more durable and impactful development may be the formalization of a U.S.-led technology bloc. This strategy seeks short-term stability while aiming for a long-term reduction in reliance on China for critical technologies.

III. Q3 2025 Earnings Season: In-Depth Analysis

A. The Tech Titans: A Detailed Report Card

This week's earnings reports made it clear that the market is no longer writing a blank check for AI-related spending. It is now actively distinguishing between disciplined, demand-driven investment and spending that is potentially speculative and margin-eroding. Companies with established, profitable platforms like AWS, Azure, and Google Cloud are being given the benefit of the doubt that their capex is meeting real customer demand. In contrast, companies like Meta, with a less clear path to monetizing their AI ambitions and a history of massive spending on long-term bets, are facing intense scrutiny.

Meta Platforms (META)

- **Pre-Earnings Trend:** The stock traded near all-time highs, with high expectations for AI-driven advertising revenue growth.
- **Results vs. Expectations:** Revenue of \$51.24 billion beat the consensus of \$49.55 billion.³⁰ However, a one-time, non-cash income tax expense of \$15.93 billion caused GAAP EPS to come in at \$1.05, a massive miss against the \$6.70 estimate.³¹ Adjusted EPS was \$7.25, beating expectations.
- **Post-Earnings Reaction:** The stock plunged 11%.¹⁴ The market looked past the one-time tax charge to the ballooning costs. Meta raised its full-year expense and capital expenditure guidance, signaling that its AI spending spree would intensify into 2026.³¹
- **Management Commentary:** CEO Zuckerberg expressed high conviction in building "personal superintelligence," while the CFO acknowledged accelerating cost growth due to AI talent acquisition and infrastructure expenses.³⁰

Microsoft (MSFT)

- **Pre-Earnings Trend:** The stock was consolidating near its highs, with expectations

centered on continued momentum in Azure.³³

- **Results vs. Expectations:** For its Q1 FY2026 (ended Sept 30, 2025), Microsoft reported revenue of \$77.7 billion and EPS of \$3.72, beating analyst expectations.³⁴ Azure revenue growth accelerated to 40%.³⁴
- **Post-Earnings Reaction:** Despite the strong beat, the stock fell 3.7% the next day.³⁶ This suggests that market expectations were extremely high, and the stock's lofty valuation required an even bigger beat or more aggressive guidance.
- **Management Commentary:** CEO Satya Nadella and CFO Amy Hood emphasized that strong demand for their cloud and AI platforms justifies continued large-scale investment.³⁴

Alphabet (GOOGL)

- **Pre-Earnings Trend:** The stock was near all-time highs, with investors focused on whether the company would cross the symbolic \$100 billion quarterly revenue milestone and on strong growth in Cloud.³⁷
- **Results vs. Expectations:** Alphabet delivered its "first-ever \$100 billion quarter," beating expectations.¹⁴ Revenue surpassed estimates, and Google Cloud revenue surged 34%.¹⁴
- **Post-Earnings Reaction:** The stock rose 2.5% to a new all-time high. The market cheered the revenue milestone and strong cloud performance, giving the company a pass on its massive AI capital expenditures.¹⁴
- **Management Commentary:** CEO Sundar Pichai stressed that AI is now "translating into real business results," citing accelerating cloud growth and strong user adoption of Gemini.³⁸

Amazon (AMZN)

- **Pre-Earnings Trend:** Amazon had been a relative laggard among the 'Magnificent Seven' this year, with investors concerned about slowing AWS growth compared to competitors.³⁹
- **Results vs. Expectations:** Amazon delivered a blowout quarter. Revenue of \$180.2 billion beat the \$177.7 billion estimate, and EPS of \$1.95 crushed the \$1.56 consensus.³⁹ Critically, AWS revenue growth re-accelerated to 20%, beating expectations.³⁹
- **Post-Earnings Reaction:** The stock soared over 11% in after-hours trading. The re-acceleration of AWS growth directly refuted a major bear thesis and signaled that AI investments were paying off.¹⁵

- **Management Commentary:** CEO Andy Jassy noted that AWS is "growing at a pace we haven't seen since 2022," citing strong demand for both AI and core infrastructure.³⁹

Apple (AAPL)

- **Pre-Earnings Trend:** The stock traded near all-time highs, with a market cap approaching \$4 trillion, amid high anticipation for the new iPhone 17 cycle.³
- **Results vs. Expectations:** Apple reported revenue of \$102.5 billion (beating the \$101.6 billion estimate) and EPS of \$1.85 (beating the \$1.77 estimate).⁴² Both Products and Services segments beat expectations, with Services showing particularly strong 15% growth.⁴²
- **Post-Earnings Reaction:** The stock moved modestly higher after the report, from around \$271 to \$277.⁴² The solid results and strong guidance for a record December quarter were enough to support the high valuation.
- **Management Commentary:** CEO Tim Cook highlighted strong demand for the iPhone 17 and projected a record December quarter. The company noted it is "significantly increasing our investments in AI".⁴²

B. High-Growth Stocks in the Spotlight

- **Celestica (CLS):** Delivered a stunning beat with Q3 revenue of \$3.19 billion and adjusted EPS of \$1.58, representing 28% and 52% year-over-year growth, respectively.⁴³ This growth was driven by hyperscale customer demand for AI datacenter infrastructure, particularly 400G/800G switches.⁴⁴ The company significantly raised its 2025 and 2026 outlook, signaling continued strong demand.⁴³
- **SoFi Technologies (SOFI):** Reported strong Q3 results with revenue of \$961.6 million and adjusted EPS of \$0.11, both beating estimates.⁴⁵ The key driver was a record 905,000 new member additions, validating its "one-stop-shop" strategy and diversification into fee-based revenue streams.⁴⁵ Management raised its 2025 guidance.⁴⁶
- **Reddit (RDDT):** Reported a massive beat with Q3 revenue up 68% year-over-year to \$585 million and diluted EPS of \$0.80, far exceeding market expectations.⁴⁷ Daily Active Uniques (DAUq) grew 19% to 116 million. The stock surged 7.6% on Friday¹⁵, driven by accelerating advertising revenue and international expansion.⁴⁸
- **Roblox (RBLX):** Reported strong growth with Q3 revenue of \$1.92 billion and a loss per share of -\$0.37, beating market expectations.⁴⁹ Bookings surged 70% year-over-year. However, despite the strong results, the stock fell 9.2% in pre-market trading.⁴⁹ This

reflected investor concerns about future growth and margin pressure, fueled by management's warnings about rising investments in infrastructure and safety, and difficult comparables for 2026.⁴⁹

C. Sector Earnings Roundup

- **Cadence Design Systems (CDNS):** Beat Q3 estimates with non-GAAP EPS of \$1.93 and revenue of \$1.339 billion.⁵¹
- **UnitedHealth Group (UNH):** Reported Q3 revenue growth of 12% to \$113.2 billion and adjusted EPS of \$2.92, raising its full-year outlook.⁵²
- **PayPal (PYPL):** Beat Q3 estimates with adjusted EPS of \$1.34 and revenue of \$8.42 billion, raising its full-year EPS guidance and sending the stock higher.⁵⁴
- **UPS (UPS):** Reported Q3 revenue of \$21.4 billion and adjusted EPS of \$1.74, beating lowered expectations.⁵⁶
- **Bloom Energy (BE):** Beat Q3 estimates with EPS of \$0.15 and revenue of \$519.05 million.⁵⁸
- **Verizon (VZ):** Beat Q3 estimates with adjusted EPS of \$1.21 and revenue of \$33.8 billion, showing solid subscriber metrics.⁵⁹
- **Boeing (BA):** Beat revenue estimates with \$23.27 billion but posted a wide miss on EPS with a loss per share of -\$7.47 versus an expected -\$5.16.⁶¹
- **CVS Health (CVS):** Beat Q3 estimates with adjusted EPS of \$1.60 and revenue of \$102.9 billion, despite a large GAAP loss due to a goodwill impairment charge.⁶³
- **Starbucks (SBUX):** Beat revenue estimates with \$9.57 billion but missed on adjusted EPS, reporting \$0.52 versus an expected \$0.55.⁶⁴
- **Coinbase (COIN):** Beat Q3 estimates with revenue of \$1.87 billion and adjusted EPS of \$1.44, driven by institutional adoption and derivatives expansion.⁶⁵
- **Roku (ROKU):** Smashed Q3 expectations, reporting a surprise profit of \$24.8 million on \$1.21 billion in revenue.⁶⁶
- **ExxonMobil (XOM) & Chevron (CVX):** ExxonMobil reported Q3 net income of \$7.5 billion (\$1.76 per share)⁶⁸, while Chevron beat estimates with adjusted EPS of \$1.85 on revenue of \$49.73 billion.⁶⁹

D. Earnings, Inflation Correlation, and Future Price Analysis

Corporate earnings and commentary are filling the void left by the absence of macro data,

providing a real-time, bottom-up view on inflation.

Companies with strong brands and demand (e.g., Apple) are maintaining pricing power. In contrast, those targeting lower-income consumers may face resistance, consistent with Powell's "K-shaped" economic recovery remarks. Rising costs for AI talent and infrastructure at Big Tech firms suggest wage inflation in specific professional fields.³⁰ Logistics companies like UPS offer insights into shipping costs and overall economic activity⁵⁷, while the results from ExxonMobil and Chevron directly reflect energy input costs.⁶⁸

Results from consumer-facing companies like Starbucks, SoFi, and PayPal provide clues on discretionary spending and consumer financial health.⁴⁵ The overall picture suggests that while goods inflation may be moderating, services inflation and wage pressures in high-demand sectors will likely remain sticky.⁷¹ This supports the Fed's cautious stance. Global inflation forecasts show a steady decline, but U.S. inflation is expected to remain above target.⁷² Therefore, future prices are analyzed to remain highly volatile in the short term before gradually stabilizing, though a sharp increase is possible depending on external variables like geopolitical risks and supply chain issues.

IV. Outlook for Next Week (November 3 - November 7, 2025): A Test of Data and Earnings

A. The Economic Calendar

The upcoming week is packed with crucial private data releases that will fill the void of delayed official statistics from the government shutdown.

Event	Date	Previous	Forecast
S&P Global Manufacturing PMI (Oct)	Nov 3 (Mon)	52.0	52.2
ISM Manufacturing PMI (Oct)	Nov 3 (Mon)	49.1	-

JOLTS Job Openings (Sep)	Nov 4 (Tue)	7.227M	-
ADP Nonfarm Employment Change (Oct)	Nov 5 (Wed)	-32K	-
S&P Global Services PMI (Oct)	Nov 5 (Wed)	54.2	55.2
ISM Non-Manufacturing PMI (Oct)	Nov 5 (Wed)	50.0	-

- **PMI Analysis (Monday & Wednesday):** The Manufacturing and Services Purchasing Managers' Indices (PMI) will be the first major gauges of economic health for October. A strong reading above 50 would suggest continued economic resilience, justifying the Fed's cautious stance and potentially dampening rate cut expectations. Conversely, a weak reading below 50 would amplify recession fears and increase pressure on the Fed to signal a December rate cut.
- **Special Focus: JOLTS Job Openings (Tuesday):** With the official jobs report delayed, Tuesday's JOLTS report for September will take on unusually high importance. A significant drop from the previous reading of 7.227 million would be interpreted as a clear sign that the labor market is cooling rapidly, supporting a dovish Fed and increasing the odds of a December cut. A number that holds steady or rises, however, would suggest the labor market remains tight, reinforcing Powell's hawkish caution and likely weighing on market sentiment.

B. Key Earnings Previews

AI & Semiconductor Majors

- **Palantir (PLTR, Mon):** Analysts expect EPS to double year-over-year to \$0.12, driven by its commercial AI Platform (AIP).⁷³ The growth rate of commercial customers and forward guidance will be key focal points.
- **AMD (AMD, Tue):** Revenue is expected to grow around 28% year-over-year to \$8.7

billion, driven by data center demand for its EPYC CPUs and MI350 series GPUs.⁷⁵ The data center segment's growth rate and commentary on competition with Nvidia will be crucial.

- **Super Micro Computer (SMCI, Tue):** A negative sentiment has formed after the company recently lowered its fiscal 2025 revenue guidance, citing economic uncertainty and tariff impacts.⁷⁷ Gross margins, which declined last quarter, and the outlook for AI server demand will be closely scrutinized. The financial position shows significant bank debt nearly equal to cash.⁷⁷
- **Qualcomm (QCOM, Wed):** Analysts expect EPS of around \$2.86 on revenue of about \$10.7 billion.⁷⁸ The recovery in the smartphone market and growth in the automotive and IoT segments will be in focus.
- **Arm Holdings (ARM, Wed):** Will report its Q2 FY2026 results.⁸⁰ Signals on royalty revenue growth from its v9 architecture and licensing momentum in data centers and AI will be critical.

Consumer & Inflation Bellwethers

- **Axon (AXON, Tue), McDonald's (MCD, Wed), Airbnb (ABNB, Thu), Wendy's (WEN, Fri):** The earnings from these companies will provide important insights into consumer spending trends and inflationary pressures. Commentary on same-store sales and pricing from McDonald's and Wendy's will indicate the health of the lower-end consumer market⁸¹, while Airbnb's booking numbers and average daily rates will be a barometer for travel and leisure demand.⁸³ Axon's results may reflect local government spending trends.⁸⁴ If these companies beat expectations, it could be interpreted as a sign that consumption remains robust, positively impacting the stock market, but it could also suggest that inflationary pressures persist, reinforcing the Fed's tightening stance. Conversely, poor results could heighten concerns of an economic slowdown, negatively affecting the market.

High-Interest Stock Previews

- **Hims & Hers Health (HIMS, Mon):** Strong year-over-year growth is expected, with an EPS of \$0.09 and revenue of \$583.7 million.⁸⁵
- **Uber (UBER, Tue):** Gross bookings are expected to show strong growth of 17-21%, but EPS is projected to decline year-over-year.⁸⁶
- **Spotify (SPOT, Tue):** The focus will be on subscriber reaction to price hikes and the impact on churn. EPS of around \$2.43 on revenue of about \$4.9 billion is expected.⁸⁷

- **Beyond Meat (BYND, Tue):** A loss of \$0.41 per share is expected.⁸⁸
- **Novo Nordisk (NVO, Wed):** Under pressure from potential U.S. drug price negotiations, with EPS expected between \$0.75-\$0.90 on revenue of about \$12 billion.⁸⁹
- **Unity Software (U, Wed):** Expected to turn profitable with a profit of \$0.17 per share.⁹¹
- **Robinhood (HOOD, Wed):** Explosive year-over-year growth is expected, with EPS of \$0.51 and revenue of \$1.21 billion, driven by crypto and options trading.⁹³
- **IonQ (IONQ, Wed):** The consensus is for a loss of \$0.24 per share, similar to the prior year.⁸⁸
- **AppLovin (APP, Wed):** Strong growth is expected, with EPS of \$2.37 and revenue of \$1.34 billion.⁹⁶
- **Figma (FIG, Wed):** A loss per share between \$1.56-\$2.08 on revenue of about \$264 million is expected.⁹⁷
- **MP Materials (MP, Thu):** A loss of \$0.17 per share is expected.⁹⁹ Commentary on the U.S.-China rare earths agreement will be critical.
- **Iris Energy (IREN, Thu):** As a bitcoin miner, profitability is tied to crypto prices and energy costs. Strong profit growth is projected.¹⁰⁰
- **SoundHound AI (SOUN, Thu):** A loss of \$0.09 per share is expected.¹⁰² The company remains unprofitable due to high operating costs.¹⁰³
- **NuScale Power (SMR, Thu):** A loss of \$0.11 per share and revenue of about \$11.3 million are expected.¹⁰⁴

V. Conclusion and Strategic Outlook

The market is currently in a precarious but upwardly biased position. The "three pillars" of Fed easing, a China truce, and strong tech earnings have provided a powerful tailwind.

- **Bull Case:** A cooling labor market (confirmed by JOLTS/PMI) forces the Fed to follow the market's dovish pricing. The truce with China holds, removing a major source of uncertainty. AI-driven productivity gains continue to drive corporate profits, spreading beyond Big Tech to related players like CLS, AMD, and SMCI, justifying high valuations.
- **Bear Case:** Sticky inflation and a resilient economy (confirmed by strong PMIs) force the Fed to maintain a hawkish pause, recalibrating rate expectations and bursting the "dovish pivot" bubble. The China truce proves temporary, and tariffs are reimposed. The market's discriminating view on AI spending spreads, causing more companies to be punished for high capex, leading to a broad tech de-rating. The data blackout is revealed to have been masking a potential slowdown, leading to a policy error and a sharp correction once data is finally released.

In the short term, the path of least resistance appears to be higher, but the number and

magnitude of risks—the Fed-market disconnect, shutdown uncertainty, and fragile geopolitics—are accumulating beneath the surface. Volatility is likely to increase as the market grapples with these contradictions. The key determinant will be whether the upcoming data pushes the Fed toward the market's dovish view or vindicates Chair Powell's hawkish caution.

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